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Captives of Geography

One of the easternmost points on the mainland of India is a quaint little settlement in Arunachal Pradesh known as Vijaynagar (see Sketch 35.1). It is situated in a narrow valley near the tri-junction of India, China and Myanmar. It lies in a salient about 100 kilometres deep, jutting into Myanmar like a dagger, and has high mountain ranges on both sides. My visit to this remote area was an unforgettable experience. It takes a trek of six days to reach Vijaynagar, which is the circle HQ. After concerted efforts for almost a year, an Assam Rifles outpost was established in November 1961 and christened Vijaynagar. Subsequently, after the Sino-India war of 1962, on the advice of the army, our government set up a colony of ex-servicemen from Assam Rifles in this sparsely populated but strategic area. Therefore, the population of this area comprises, besides the tribals (belonging mostly to the Yobin and Lisu tribes), Nepali-speaking families of Assam Rifles ex-servicemen. They subsist on farming and forest produce. At the eastern tip of this salient is the Chaukan Pass, which is almost equidistant from Guwahati in the west and Kunming in China, which is about 600 kilometres to its east. I do not think there is any other circle HQ in India that requires a trek of six days from the roadhead over such treacherous terrain.

In April 2010, I decided to visit Vijaynagar and see for myself the situation on the ground. We took off at 7 a.m. in an MI 17 helicopter. Although the weather was not ideal we landed an hour later at Dibrugarh to refuel. There we received frantic calls about the poor visibility and bad weather conditions at Vijaynagar, and in the narrow valley that we had to fly through. My advisers